

SOUTHERN AFRICA

THE EIGHT COUNTRIES THAT MAKE UP southern Africa have much in common. Once governed by European settlers, almost all of them had to struggle to achieve independence. Many endured years of vicious warfare. Today, all eight countries are independent, multiracial democracies. Their climates range from warm and mild in the south to tropical in the north, while the landscape includes both deserts and rain forests, vast plains, and towering mountain ranges. The population varies in wealth from extremely rich industrialists and landowners in South Africa to hunter-gatherer Bushmen in the Kalahari Desert.

Magnificent Table Mountain towers above Cape Town in the Cape Peninsula, South Africa. The Cape is home to many unique species of plants and flowers.



A LAND OF CONTRASTS

The landscape of southern Africa varies from the Namib and Kalahari deserts in the west and center to lush vegetation and tropical forests in the north. Inland, vast grassy savannas and woodlands are home to much of the region's wildlife, from the minute *dik-dik* (the world's smallest antelope) to the African elephant. Game reserves and national parks have been set up to protect endangered species. Tourists come from all over the world to visit the reserves and enjoy the dramatic scenery.



KALAHARI BUSHMEN

The Bushmen, or San, of the Kalahari Desert are one of the few groups of hunter-gatherers left in Africa. These people live and work together in small, tightly knit communities. Traditionally they moved from place to place, searching for insects and edible plants and hunting small animals with poisonous arrows. Today, however, many of the San live a more settled existence.

MINERAL RICHES

Southern Africa is rich in mineral resources. Much of the world's gold, diamonds, uranium, and copper come from the region, and have transformed the local economies. Botswana is the most dependent upon its minerals. Almost 80 percent of the country's export earnings come from diamonds. South Africa is the world's largest producer of gold, and Namibia has one of the world's largest uranium mines. Coal is southern Africa's major source of energy. South Africa, Zimbabwe, Botswana, and Mozambique all have large coal reserves.



Before 1994, demonstrations against apartheid were held throughout South Africa.

POLITICS

Southern Africa is dominated by the politics of South Africa. After 1948, South Africa pursued a policy of separate development for white and black people known as apartheid. South Africa tried to weaken the neighboring countries that opposed it. It supported rebels fighting the Angolan and Mozambique governments, and helped those resisting black rule in Zimbabwe and Namibia. The ending of white rule in 1994 led to better relations between South Africa and its neighbors.



OKAVANGO DELTA

Unlike most rivers, which run out to the sea, the Okavango River runs inland into a desert. The river begins in Angola, then flows southeast through Namibia into a delta in the Kalahari Desert in Botswana. The vast swamps and waterways of the river and its delta cover an area of more than 8,500 sq miles (22,000 sq km). This provides a haven for a wide variety of plants and animals. People travel into the swamps in dugout canoes, called *mokoros*.

